Chapel Hill Friends Meeting

Newsletter: Fourth Month, 2026

Monthly Query: *How can we make the meeting a community in which each person is accepted and nurtured, and strangers are welcome?*

Monthly Worship Tip from the M&W Committee: *Not all vocal ministry will be equally meaningful to all present. Remember, ministry that does not speak to your condition may nevertheless be valuable to others. Be patient. Take care to separate the message from the minister.*

Contents

Monthly Calendar 1
Upcoming Zoom Fora 2
Upcoming Events 2
- Piedmont Friends Retreat & Annual Sessions, June 5 - 7 2

Announcements 3
- P&J Suggests We Write Our Senators about DHS 3
- Quaker House GI Rights Hotline Calls 4
- Interfaith Activities this Spring and Summer 4
- Your Suggestions or Comments Regarding CHFM Benevolences 6
- A Quaker-led, Interfaith Immersion into Spirit and Identity 6
- Meditation Dances at Durham Friends 7
- CFS Beloved Community Offerings this Coming Spring 8

Recurring Announcements 8
- InterFath Council Committee Is Seeking Volunteers 8
- Zoom Tech Hosts Wanted 8
- Inter-Faith Council Pantry Needs Donated Food Items 8
- FRIENDS, PLEASE LIMIT YOUR WEEKDAY MEETINGHOUSE VISITS. 9
- Newsletter & eNews Reminder 9

Recurring Events 9
- Prayers for Healing/Holding in the Light, 2nd and 4th Wednesday, 7-8:30 pm 9
- Meeting for Worship with Attention to Peace in Palestine. Thursdays, 5:30pm 10

Pendle Hill Worship via Zoom, Daily, 8:30-9:10am 10
Pray for Peace - From Friends House Moscow, Daily 10
Business Meeting Minutes 12
Appendix A: Peace and Justice Annual Report 14
Appendix B: Margaret Vimmerstedt Biography 17
Appendix C: Melissa Ruof Biography 18

Monthly Calendar

First Sunday	• 8:15 - 9:15 am - **Early worship in the meeting room** • 9:30 - 10:30 am - **Forum via Zoom** • 11:00 am - 12:00 - **Worship in the meeting room** • 11:00 am - 12:00 - **Online worship via Zoom** • After meeting - **Potluck in the schoolhouse**
Second Sunday	• 8:15 - 9:15 am - **Early worship in the meeting room** • 9:30 - 10:30 am - **Forum via Zoom** • 11:00 am - 12:00 - **Blended Meeting in the meeting room and via Zoom**
Third Sunday	• 8:00 - 9:00 am - **Early worship in the meeting room** (reverts to 8:15 the following week) • 9:00 - 10:30 am - **Meeting for Worship with Attention to Business via Zoom** • 11:00 am - 12:00 - **Worship in the meeting room** • 11:00 am - 12:00 - **Online worship via Zoom**
Fourth Sunday	• Same as Second Sunday - **Blended Meeting**
Fifth Sunday	• Same as First Sunday, but without potluck

Upcoming Zoom Fora

https://www.chapelhillfriends.org/forums.html

April 5: Peace & Justice Forum: Priority setting for FCNL

April 12: Sarah Junkin Woodard speaks about the Jubilee House Community

April 19: Meeting for Worship with Attention to Business (no forum)

April 26: Kate Fitch: The Testimony of Simplicity

Upcoming Events

Piedmont Friends Retreat & Annual Sessions, June 5 - 7

GATHERED in SPIRIT, NOURISHED in NATURE, NURTURED in COMMUNITY
2026 Piedmont Friends Retreat & Annual Sessions
Friday – Sunday, June 5-7 at Haw River State Park

REGISTRATION OPENS APRIL 1st!
Registration closes for accommodations and meals on May 10th
https://www.piedmontfriends.org/2026-retreat-annual-sessions
Go to the above page to register and for updates

- The Retreat begins Friday afternoon. Enjoy the nature of Haw River State Park, north of Greensboro
- Friday evening Family Night Gathering: intergenerational games and open-mic Coffeehouse
- Saturday morning activities include nature walk, small group workshops and interest group conversations

- Saturday morning deeper-dive workshops with Right Sharing of World Resource's Tracy Hjelt-Sullivan: The Power of Enough and Raleigh Friends Meeting's Seeds of War/Seeds of Peace queries responding in Spirit to a world in distress
- Saturday afternoon's Annual Sessions, Piedmont Friends meeting for worship with attention to business
- Saturday evening: Family Contra/Folk Dancing, Fire Circle
- Sunday morning Singing, followed by Meeting for Worship
- A Full Program for Children and Youth (elementary; middle & high school)
- Peaceful nature trails, lake activities, swimming pool, fire circle, disc golf
- Comfortable motel accommodations, cabins for youth
- Thoughtfully prepared meals, accommodating special diets

Announcements

P&J Suggests We Write Our Senators about DHS

Dear Friends,

Here is an opportunity to join other meetings and FCNL advocacy teams across the nation in drafting handwritten letters to Congress regarding DHS enforcement and immigration. Along with Mary Brandon from the Raleigh Friends Meeting, Kathy Lucente, (on behalf of the CHFM Peace and Justice Committee) will deliver these letters to the offices of Sen.Tillis and Sen. Budd in early April.

If you choose to write a letter or two, Kathy will be in the lobby of the Chapel Friends Meeting before and after meeting this coming Easter Sunday to receive yours.

Included below are some materials for your review:
-evidence of Tillis' and Budd's engagement in these issues
Tips for Effective Letter Writing to Congress

- FCNL has identified Sen. Tillis as persuadable on the issue of immigration reform and ICE activities which align with our values of treating all with dignity, respect, and due process including during the immigration and enforcement process.
- Tillis demands accountability from DHS - See the link below to to read a letter from Sen. Tillis to DHS
  https://www.tillis.senate.gov/2026/2/tillis-demands-accountability-from-dhs-on-immigration -enforcement-operations

- Senator BuddÂ - Budd criticizes DHS tactics https://www.wfae.org/politics/2026-01-30/sen-ted-budd-calls-for-changes-to-immigration-enf orcement-votes-against-dhs-funding-bill
- https://www.budd.senate.gov/priority-issues/ Senator Budd - Issues page
- FCNL Tips for Effective Letter Writing to Congress.pages (751K)

If you prefer to type your letter, please email it to Kathy (klucente60@gmail.com) by Sunday. She will print it out and include it with the others.
Thank you.

Quaker House GI Rights Hotline Calls

Curt Torell shares with Friends:

The following excerpts updates the activity of the Hotline:

Laws tend to become fuzzy in times of war, and this administration's use of the military has pushed beyond previous limits. Every caller has their own concerns and their own version of opposition, but taken together we have seen a pattern of military people losing trust in the government's use of the armed forces. Some began rethinking when they saw the carnage in Ukraine. For others it started after seeing the genocide in Gaza. When National Guard units were sent to US cities, the phones got busier. Additional calls came in response to operations in Venezuela. Then with the Iran invasion, calls spiked much higher. We're still getting our regular calls about things like hardship/dependency, medical issues, DEP, AWOL, and commuting distance. Add to that a wave of new calls about conscientious objection and options for dealing with illegal orders, and the result is a very busy hotline.

Many people and groups have been circulating the hotline number alongside their own simple messaging targeted towards military members. One of the most common ones reads: "You have the right to refuse illegal orders." Some callers have mentioned finding the hotline through these channels. At the same time, the reality they face is far more complicated than the message they saw. We cannot falsely assure people that the military will protect any rights to question the orders it gives. Instead we go over both the real risks and different options they have for navigating these times.

Interfaith Activities this Spring and Summer

Carolyn White shares with Friends:

Please read for an opportunity to participate in an interfaith activity this spring and summer.

Faith250 is a program whose purpose is to invite diverse faith communities together to create a sacred space where we listen deeply to one another, clarify our shared civic values, and celebrate our hopes for America. Relationships are the groundwork for faithful civic engagement; we want to know one another well enough that, when the moment calls for it, we are ready to act together.

Our approach centers on relationship-building through fellowship and small-group study of four of America's "sacred texts." Through shared learning, we seek to form communities capable of honest reflection about our nation's past, present, and future, and to discern a public civic ritual around July 4, 2026—one that will gather our community with hope, invite meaningful reflection, and renew our shared commitment to the common good.

We envision Faith250 as both a project and a pathway: a meaningful experience in its own right and a gateway to future involvement with the wider ecosystem of organizations strengthening democracy and civic life.

This work is explicitly non-partisan. Through Faith250, we seek to:

- Grow shared civic understanding and practical skills, equipping participants to engage public life thoughtfully and wisely in service of a more perfect union.
- Cultivate relationships across differences, building the trust required for the long, patient work of forming that union together.
- Lay the groundwork for collective action, preparing communities to respond side by side to the real challenges we face locally.

Here is how you can participate:

Attend the Community Launch at the University Baptist Church (Chapel Hill), Great Hall April 12, 2026 at 6 to 7:30 PM.

Join one or more of the study groups:

Chapel of the Cross: Thursdays at 8:00 AM on April 23, May 7, May 21 and June 4

Kehillah Community Synagogue: Wednesdays, 12:30 PM to 1:45 PM on April 22, May 6, May 20, June 3

Each week, discussion will focus on a different text.

Week of April 19: *The Declaration of Independence*
Week of May 3: Emma Lazarus' *New Colossus*
Week of May 17: *America the Beautiful*
Week of June 1: *What to the Slave is the Fourth of July?* By Frederick Douglass

Details about a public witness/ritual June 14 is forthcoming.

Contact Carolyn White (chwhitenc@gmail.com) for more details and information about registration.

Your Suggestions or Comments Regarding CHFM Benevolences

Deborah Gibbs shares with Friends:

Chapel Hill Friends Meeting provides modest financial support for organizations that are immediately relevant to our membership through its discretionary benevolences. The benevolences "must be either Quaker affiliated or local organizations that reflect our Meeting's values and with which Meeting members are closely affiliated." Current recipients are: FCNCL, Bridging the Gap, Orange County Remembrance, Orange-Alamance Prison Ministry, and Ramallah Friends School. These benevolences are in addition to our "legacy benevolences," the American Friends Service Committee, Carolina Friends School, Friends Committee on National Legislation, Interfaith Council for Social Services, and Quaker House.

An ad hoc committee (Jennifer Bills, Deborah Gibbs, and David Waterman) has been asked to discern the leadings of the Meeting for the discretionary benevolences for the 2025-26 budget year. Please forward any comments on existing benevolences or suggestions for other recipients to Deborah at GibbsDeborah@gmail.com. Any suggestions for or suggestions should reflect the organization's Quaker affiliation or importance to the Meeting.

A Quaker-led, Interfaith Immersion into Spirit and Identity

Quaker Harmon shares with Friends:

Amid the mist and quiet beauty of a mountaintop Costa Rican cloud forest, Earth & Ember invites spiritual seekers and contemplatives to explore how their lives can be rooted in compassion and peace—while still engaging with a world marked by injustice, greed, and cruelty. Each day offers centering practices, meaningful participation in our rainforest

community, rich spiritual conversation, and the wisdom of local scientists, artists, and peacemakers.

Join us for five days of reflection, community, and renewal in the mountains that have inspired generations of Friends.

When: **July 16–21**
Where: **Monteverde, Costa Rica**
Focus: **Spirit, Creation, Community, and Peace**
Learn More & Register Here: https://earthnember.com/

Meditation Dances at Durham Friends

Jack Wolf here from Eno Friends Meeting, Hillsborough, and prior Chapel Hill Friends Meeting. I am involved in a new project, Dance Meditations, and sending this out to my Quaker Friends. I am starting a series of Dances at Durham Friends Meeting Fellowship Room on Saturdays 4-6 PM starting April 11 with May 2 and May 23 also reserved. This will be open to the public, but I would also hope to get some of my Quaker friends quaking. The Dances are in the manner of Ecstatic Dance or Dance Waves, for those familiar, and are 90 minutes of unstructured movement to recorded music designed to create a meditative and spiritual space. There are no steps or protocol or need to exert beyond your comfort level and there will be chairs and we move or sit at will. The only structure is that we have no conversation. Also because of the nature of the dance we ask people to arrive on time. Arrive at 4. We will circle up at 4:05 Dance at 4:15 and have a closing circle followed by socializing at 5:45
I go into a little more depth on our intentions and concepts on this Facebook Group you are free to peruse or join Dance Meditations | Facebook as well as on the Facebook Event here Dance Meditation | Facebook
There is a history of this type of dance originated by the late Gabrielle Roth who developed the 5 Rhythms concept , often called Ecstatic Dance or 5 Rhythms. Each dance set will be at the discretion of the set weaver and they may or may not follow the 5 Rhythms concept, but we are all influenced by her ideas (https:www.5rhythms.com) We also have a longstanding teacher of 5 Rhythms at Eno Meeting in Richard Jerram who is planning a forum/workshop in May and contact me if interested. I am putting together the first set on April ll and Laura Aliberti May 2. The tentative name of my set is Mother Africa as I am greatly influenced by music of the continent which is also our Homo Sapiens birthplace. There will be no charge, though contributions, only to pay the facility rental will be accepted, and all of the production is volunteer with no profit being made.
Once again the specs: Dance Meditation Saturdays April 11, May 2, May 23 4-6 PM, Durham Friends Meeting Fellowship Room 404 Alexander Ave. Durham.. Free of Charge. For more information contact Jack Wolf 919-245-8393 jackhwolf49@gmail.com.

CFS Beloved Community Offerings this Coming Spring

Pam Schwingl shares with Friends:
From Carolina Friends School Beloved Community Institute:

UPCOMING WELLNESS AND TRANSFORMATIONAL TRAVEL-LEARNING PROGRAMS
Registration opens soon!

- **Quaker Journey**, a weeklong visit to the 17th-century roots of Quakerism in the breathtaking Lake District of Northern England. **2-9 August 2026**

You can see links for these and additional offerings at www.cfsnc.org/AdultEnrichment.

Recurring Announcements

InterFath Council Committee Is Seeking Volunteers

We invite anyone interested in becoming, or knowing more about being an IFC Committee Member to please contact Carolyn White.

We welcome volunteers to help with food preparation and service at ICF every second Thursday for lunch: 10a - 1p, and/or every second Friday for dinner 4p-6:30p. Volunteers are welcome for part of the shift, or the full shift.

Zoom Tech Hosts Wanted

Support Chapel Hill Friends Meeting's Zoom worship and forums by becoming a tech host. The role is much more simple than you would imagine. Trust us! We need your help and will train you. Please contact the Zoom Subcommittee if interested, or have questions: zoom@chapelhillfriends.org.

Inter-Faith Council Pantry Needs Donated Food Items

Please consider IFC's needs when doing your shopping. There is a basket in the meetinghouse foyer for food donations. IFC has requested the following food items: coffee, hot chocolate,

canned protein, canned pork and beans, canned soup (not vegetable), boxed cereal, cake mixes, instant foods, ramen noodles. Thank you!

FRIENDS, PLEASE LIMIT YOUR WEEKDAY MEETINGHOUSE VISITS.

The CFS Early School teachers, parents and guests have priority use of the meetinghouse parking lot from 7:30 AM to 6:00 PM Monday through Friday throughout the calendar year. If you must visit the meetinghouse during weekday hours, please alert John Hite, the Meetinghouse Resident, at least one day ahead. Email: johnthequaker@gmail.com or call: 919-929-5377.

Newsletter & eNews Reminder

Please send items for the weekly eNews email and the monthly print Newsletter to news@chapelhillfriends.org.

- The deadline for weekly eNews is *Wednesday* 5 pm.
- The deadline for the monthly print Newsletter is on the *last day of the month*.

To unsubscribe, email to news@chapelhillfriends.org with the subject line, Unsubscribe.

Note: If you think that you haven't received your weekly enews or monthly newsletter, it helps to add news@chapelhillfriends.org to your contacts. Otherwise it might go to your Spam folder (and likewise for other chapelhillfriends.org mailing lists such as pfym@chapelhillfriends.org).

Recurring Events

Prayers for Healing/Holding in the Light, 2nd and 4th Wednesday, 7-8:30 pm

YOU ARE INVITED TO PARTICIPATE IN Virtual Prayers for Healing/Holding in the Light on the 2nd and 4th Wednesday of each month, 7:00 to 8:30 PM. Join us when you can for as long as you wish - from your own home.

Do you have a name or a group of people to add to - or remove from - the list of those we will hold in our hearts and prayers? If so, please send to: prayers@chapelhillfriends.org. The list of names to be held in the Light will be renewed each month. Names must be resubmitted each month to be maintained on the list. We'll send an updated list on Wednesday afternoons. Thank you for joining us!

This virtual prayer service continues under the care of the Care and Counsel Committee and each week, a committee member will collect and post the names that are submitted and will read them aloud during the time of the service.

Meeting for Worship with Attention to Peace in Palestine. Thursdays, 5:30pm

You are invited to join Meeting for Worship with Attention to Peace in Palestine and Israel at 5:30 p.m. ET / 2:30 p.m. PT.

Join on Zoom:
https://afsc-org.zoom.us/j/85831333364?pwd=VEtPTUZuYk5hTHV2OGs1VzRkY0ZKUT09
Meeting ID: 858 3133 3364
Passcode: 759311

Pendle Hill Worship via Zoom, Daily, 8:30-9:10am

Pendle Hill Quaker Study, Retreat, and Conference Center is now opening their daily morning worship to everyone, by way of Zoom or phone. A lovely opportunity for gathered worship every morning. “A handful of Pendle Hill residents continue to gather daily in the Barn – from 8:30am to 9:10am Eastern Time – expanding the 90-year-long tradition of daily worship here on campus. Beginning the week of March 16, 2020, we started an experiment of opening the circle of worship to YOU in your home. You can join us here via Zoom.”
https://pendlehill.org/explore/worship/join-us-online-for-worship-in-the-barn/?bblinkid=210290749&bbemailid=19903873&bbejrid=1408822779

Note: The above link takes you *not* to the meeting but to a page of general instructions. Look for the sentence “You can join us via Zoom **here**, or by clicking on the image below.”

Pray for Peace - From Friends House Moscow, Daily

Link to the Daily Meeting for Worship for Peace sponsored by FHM/FHMSA: (Friends House Moscow)

Join Zoom Meeting
https://us02web.zoom.us/j/4165005614?pwd=NUtieEtqbDBYbjBrcGdMMzBKQ3drQT09
Meeting ID: 416 500 5614
Passcode: 182805

The room opens at 8:45am Pacific time (10:45 EST); worship begins on the hour and ends an hour later. After worship there will be time to share brief thoughts that did not rise to the level of ministry. You may also want to rename yourself indicating your geographic location. There will be no audible indicator when one enters or leaves, and everyone will be muted on entry. Please leave yourself muted unless giving ministry.

Ministry may also be shared in the chat, but it is not the place for private conversations. If you are new to Quaker unprogrammed worship and wish to talk with someone about it, send a message to the host and someone can join you in a breakout room.

Business Meeting Minutes

Chapel Hill Friends Meeting
Minutes of the March 15, 2026, Meeting for Worship with Attention to Business, online via Zoom

Jeff Brown, Jennifer Leeman, Quaker Harmon, Margaret Vimmerstedt, Monteze Snyder, Susan Newcomer, David Waterman, Carolyn Stuart, Kate Fitch, Hank Elkins, Melissa Ruof, Tori Toles, Carolyn White, Tom Ludlow, Tom Hickey, Hart Pillow, Wendy Michener, Tom Munk, Alice Carlton, Paul Munk, Colleen Fey, Tom McQuiston, Susan Peterson, Buffie Webber, Astra Titus, Deborah Gibbs, Herb Derby, Lynn Drake, Buzz Borchardt, Linda Patterson, Julia Cleaver, Ann Miller, Marion Schoenbach, John Hite, Matt Drake, Dave Curtin, Kurt Torrel, Jasmine McKewen, Evelyn Fender-Lee, Nancy Milio

1. We opened with worship and the query, "As I learn from others, how do I give freely from what I have gained?"

2. The minutes of the February 2026 Meeting for Worship with Attention to Business were approved.

3. Tom Ludlow, co-clerk of the Peace & Justice (P&J) Committee, presented the committee's Annual report (Appendix A). Astra, committee co-clerk, invited Friends to join the Racial Equity subcommittee and noted that P&J would welcome opportunities to collaborate with other committees. Friends accepted the report, with appreciation for the work that has been to preserve the P&J committee and the careful documentation of how the committee has evolved over the past year.

4. On behalf of Peace & Justice Committee, Tom Munk, asked that the Meeting approve sending a statement asking Representative Valerie Foushee to support a resolution that recognizes that genocide is happening in Gaza. This request is a follow-up to the genocide statement we approved at the last Meeting for Worship with Attention to Business. Concern was raised about naming a specific piece of legislation since 501(c)(3) organizations are not supposed to lobby. Other Friends clarified that the rules on lobbying address "substantial" levels of lobbying and this falls within accepted levels. A Friend raised the concern that asking her to "show moral leadership" questions her moral strength and suggested a revision to "your moral leadership". Friends approved sending the statement with the addition of "your" before moral and on additional edit. The final statement reads as follows:

Dear Representative Foushee,

The Chapel Hill Friends Meeting requests that you co-sponsor H.Res. 876, which recognizes the genocide of the Palestinian people in Gaza.

Chapel Hill Friends recently came to unity to support several major Quaker organizations in signing onto the international Quaker statement, "Quakers Discern Genocide is Occurring in Gaza." Our logical next step is asking our Representative in Congress to do the same in her realm.

Please let us know if you too will show your moral leadership by co-sponsoring H.Res. 876, and if you cannot, please tell us your reasons.

5. Carolyn White, clerk of Ministry and Worship Committee, presented a recommendation that Maragret Vimmerstedt be approved for membership in the Meeting and read a biography of Margaret (Appendix B). Friends approved Margaret's membership with joy. A welcoming committee was formed including Carolyn White (clerk), Ann Miller, Alice Carlton, and Linda Patterson.

6. Julia Cleaver presented Ministry & Worship Committee's recommendation for transfer of Melissa Ruof's membership from Austin Friends Meeting to our Meeting and read her biography (Appendix C). Friends approved Melissa's membership with enthusiasm. The following Friends agreed to join Julia in planning a welcoming celebration: Tori Toles, Tom Ludlow, and Deborah Gibbs. The welcoming may also include Tony Hickey, whose membership also was recently approved.

7. The Clerk recommended three Friends to serve on this year's ad hoc committee to discern discretionary benevolences for the 2025-2026 fiscal year. The recommended Friends are Deborah Gibbs (convener), Jennifer Bills, and David Waterman. Friends approved the membership of the ad hoc committee.

8. Tom McQuiston, clerk of Transition & Support Committee, read the committee's Annual Report (Appendix D). Tom noted that this is the 20th year that our meeting has been providing support for men at Orange County Correctional. During that time, we have had over 3,000 men visit from the prison and have made over 3,000 visits to the prison. These visits have enriched us in spiritual ways that are difficult to sum up. Other Friends affirmed the contributions of the men to our community. Friends accepted the annual report with gratitude.

9. Kate Fitch reported that Adult Religious Education Committee (ARE) is exploring the possibility of offering forums in a blended format. Due to the limited amount of time, discussion of this topic will be added to the agenda for the April business meeting. Please send your thoughts on having forums in-person with the option of joining by Zoom (blended format) versus continuing with forums on Zoom only. Please share your thoughts with Kate Fitch, clerk of ARE.

10. On behalf of the Finance Committee, David Waterman was happy to report that as of February 28th, we had received contributions of $84,332, 102% of our contributions goal for the

2025-26 fiscal year. We are very grateful to all who have contributed so far this year, and especially for heeding of our encouragement that you make contributions by March 31, the date when we need to decide if we can pay for our benevolences in full. Our committee is also encouraged by this result for the upcoming 2026-27 fiscal year. Our contributions budget for next year is likely to again rise significantly due to the prospective hiring of a zoom tech host to manage a move to weekly blended meetings, as well as probably continuing increases in insurance and some other obligations line items. He also asked Friends to continue donating, noting that last year we used the additional funds collected to build up reserve funds.

11. Jeff Brown, Clerk, reported that he has received a request for membership from Megan Lewis that he will refer to Ministry and Worship.

12. The next Meeting for Worship with Attention to Business is planned for 9:00 AM on April 19, 2026.

13. Announcements: Save the dates for the Piedmont Friends Yearly Meeting & Fellowship retreat and annual sessions, June 5-7, 2026, at New Hope Camp and Conference Center.

14. We closed with silent worship.

Jeff Brown, Clerk, and Jennifer Leeman, Recording Clerk

Appendix A: Peace and Justice Annual Report

Peace and Justice Committee of the Chapel Hill Friends Meeting

Annual Report – March 8, 2026

Over a year ago, despite the best efforts of the Nominations Committee, the membership of the Peace and Justice Committee, and attendance at its often-contentious monthly meetings, dropped to only four people. The Committee was not functioning well. The Ministry and Worship Committee considered laying the Committee down, but collaborated instead with a series of three listening sessions with the Committee.

These sessions occurred between July and September, 2024. We found these sessions powerful and helpful. Reports of the sessions were sent to three concerned committees: Ministry and Worship, Nominations, and Care and Counsel. The committee was not immediately laid down, but changes were made, including a commitment to rotate membership on the regular meeting cycle, with a maximum of two three-year terms. As a result, the committee membership changed and new co-clerks were identified.

Since one of the problems identified was the need for better communication with the Meeting, we thought that an elucidation of the existing statement of P&J's responsibilities might be a good start. In May, 2025, P&J brought the following "Vision Statement" to a Forum:

Our vision for the Peace and Justice Committee is that it will be a space to nurture clearness and provide support for Friends' activities regarding peace and social justice. It welcomes Friends who want to better understand how aspects of social injustice and violence affect others and themselves. With the participation of Friends who are linked to other peace and social justice groups, it will explore and recommend ways CHFM might support and connect with these groups. When led by the Spirit, it will draft statements of conscience for consideration by CHFM for Worship with Attention to Business. Although meetings are open to all, members of the committee will be nominated and appointed in the usual manner by the CHFM, serving usually not more than two, three-year terms.

The first question posed to Meeting members and attenders at that Forum was, "Should CHFM have a Peace and Justice Committee?" The response was positive and the input was useful. Attendance at P&J meetings has grown and new members of the Committee, nominated by the Nominations Committee and approved by the MFWAB, have joined and remain.

The responsibilities of P&J are complex, challenging and time consuming. P&J is a venue where Friends bring many varied issues and concerns to be considered for action. The committee, by nature, is made up of people who are inclined to embrace all issues of social concern and want to do something about them. Between presenting Forums and discerning which issues are appropriate for Meeting to address and how P&J will bring them to Meeting (a Minute or a Forum or working with other committees), the P&J agenda is full.

In that context, the committee requested, and was granted permission to give up, the responsibility of discerning and recommending the recipients of the non-legacy "other"

benevolences which the Meeting gives in the spring. That work is now done by an Ad Hoc committee appointed by MWAB.

In January of 2023, Adult Religious Education asked Peace and Justice if they would take responsibility for presenting a Forum on the first Sunday of every month and P&J accepted the offer which streamlined the process. Since then, P&J has filled First Sunday Forum, and we are happy to have this gift. Forums presented included the following: Fayetteville Meeting's minute of intention to protect immigrants; Climate change – Cathy Buckley; Gaza perspectives – Joe Groves; Why do we treat immigrants so unkindly? – Patrick O'Neill and Mary Rider, Raleigh Catholic Workers; Cultivating anti-racism in our children – Astra Titus; Seeds of War/Seeds of Peace - The Working Group, Raleigh Friends; How can we help our immigrant community with the challenges they're facing – Durham Friends; Quakers Discern Genocide is Occurring in Gaza and Urge Courageous Action. Where Does CHFM Stand? – Tom Munk.

The issue of Gaza and Israel and the immigrant wars of the current Administration have been central to our Agenda and will continue to be. Developing a response to our country's war on Iran is our latest concern. Issues of war, military personnel, local poverty, and incarceration are addressed by standing committees (Quaker House, IFC and prison ministry) and we support them by sharing our first of the month Forum spot on request.

The Racial Equity Subcommittee was on hiatus while P&J regrouped this past year. It will be collaborating with other Meeting Committees as well as community leaders in the area of racial justice to bring more education and opportunities to the Meeting.

We encourage members and attenders to work with us in the following ways:

- Attend our meetings. They are open to all and occur on second Sundays from 1:30 to 3:00. The Zoom location is the same as that used for Forums and Meeting for Worship.
- Bring your concerns to the committee or its clerks: Astra Titus and Tom Ludlow
- Consider joining the committee: talk to us or members of the Nominations committee if interested.

Signed: Tom Ludlow and Astra Titus, co-clerks. Jennifer Bills, recording clerk. Lydia Kiefer, Barry Mackichan, Tom Munk, members.

Appendix B: Margaret Vimmerstedt Biography

3/8/26

Margaret is close to her 3 siblings and extended family who live all around the US. She grew up in Wooster, OH and married Loren Hintz of Tiffin, OH. They are parents to Carl Hintz, who is married to Rachel May and lives in Raleigh. Margaret's parents, Mary and Jack Vimmerstedt, were very important to her. Both have passed away, Mary in 2019 and Jack in 2021. They lived by values of care for the environment, education, involvement in community, and family happiness.

Margaret attended Earlham College where she often went to Clear Creek Friends meeting on the Earlham campus. She was a runner and played violin. She enjoyed studying Chemistry and was able to study in France for 6 months.

She moved to Cleveland for medical school at Case Western Reserve University. She spent 1 summer as a back country ranger in Olympic National Park, a tempting career alternate. She studied Spanish and spent 2 months in Chiapas, Mexico at rural hospitals. She completed medical school, and moved to Burlington, Vermont for residency in Internal Medicine.

Vermont had beautiful sunsets, mountains, Lake Champlain, bicycle routes in the country and contra dancing. However, residency was extremely hard work. In looking for a job, she was interested in College Health and wanted to be in a university community.

Margaret moved to Chapel Hill in 1988 to work at UNC Campus Health Services. She made friends with some returned Peace Corps volunteers who spoke Spanish and went with them on a canoe trip where she met Loren Hintz in Roanoke Rapids, NC.

Soon, Margaret and Loren traveled to Central America. They were married in Ohio. Margaret continued patient care at UNC Campus Health for over 30 years. Every summer she volunteered at a 1 week summer camp for youth with diabetes. She has continued this work with the Diabetes Family Connection. She and Loren have been supportive of each other in their professions and as parents.

Margaret joined United Church of Chapel Hill in 1990 and attended for several years however the Sunday school was not a good fit for Carl. He liked CHFM first day school where teachers would ask the children what they thought, not tell them what to think.

Margaret enjoys music, especially singing and playing the violin. She is in a community orchestra, Chapel Hill Philharmonia, and a folk-dance band, Scandimonium.

Margaret and Loren enjoy birding together and camping a few times a year. Both enjoy reading and learning about natural sciences.

Margaret appreciates the manner of worship at Friends Meeting that allows each person an inner experience and promotes inquiry and discovery rather than a uniform creed.

Appendix C: Melissa Ruof Biography

I was born and raised in Austin Minnesota in a family of five: Mother, father, older sister, and older brother. They are now all deceased and I miss them. The Austin school system had a great music program so I was able to get a good start on my violin life there. I attended and earned the Bachelor of Music degree at the Oberlin Conservatory of Music.

I have two children from my first marriage. My daughter Anna and her husband John live in Austin TX and have two daughters. My son Holmes and his wife Louise live outside of Pittsboro and have a son and a daughter.

My career was as a free-lance musician in the Washington DC/Baltmore MD area, playing in many small and large orchestras and chamber groups for a variety of events. I also had a private violin/viola/chamber music teaching studio in DC and was on the faculty of a large community music school.

Since retirement, in the past 15 years in Austin TX, I have had a vibrant non-professional music life, playing in several community orchestras and with many chamber music friends.

I'm happy to say that I'm beginning to find my musical family here in NC too.

When I lived in Washington DC I started faithfully attending Friends Meeting of Washington. Like many people I was looking for a faith community that was unlike the one I grew up in, which in my youth I saw as hypocritical. I slowly grew to feel that Quaker Meeting was an important, essential part of my life, though I was not yet ready to take the step of becoming a member. In the mid 90's I was a student at Pendle Hill for three terms which was a transformative experience. It was there that I learned the practice of Centering Prayer which I still practice daily,

In the 2000's I lived in a low-income black neighborhood in Baltimore and was part of a church community there which welcomed white people to the neighborhood as neighbors, working together to build a strong healthy community. The church members created ministries which work to address some of the needs there. Several ministries are oriented towards helping women addicted to drugs and alcohol to return to health and to their communities in healthy ways. One ministry works with men released from prison to help them find their way back into the community. One of the ministries that I helped to create is a community art center focussing on entrepreneurial creative arts endeavors with the young people in the community.

While living in Baltimore, I visited a man on Maryland's Death Row, for ten years. After I moved to Austin, Texas I visited a man on Texas's Death Row for 15 years as part of Friends Meeting of Austin's prison ministry.

In Austin, Texas, I at last became a member of the Religious Society of Friends at Friends Meeting of Austin where I served on the Worship and Ministry Committee and the Care and Counsel Committee.

I look forward to being an active part of Chapel Hill Friends Meeting.

Transition and Support Committee Annual Report
April 2024 to March 2025

This report covers our activities as we continue to serve men in Orange Correctional Center (OCC) as well the previously incarcerated men whom we support when they return to the Chapel Hill community. Most of these activities have included volunteers from the Meeting, the community, in addition to the Transition and Support Committee (TSC).

YOKEFELLOWS at OCC: Along with other volunteers, four TSC members attended Tuesday evening meetings of Yokefellows at the Peace Center. Two members of the TSC have a 20-year history of attending/volunteering with Yokefellows. Seated at round tables with the volunteers are usually two-four men, providing an opportunity to get to know some of the men and develop meaningful long-term relationships. The conversations with the men also facilitate finding out who wants to attend Meeting for Worship, the book club, and interest in a support team if/when they are released into the local community.

The Tuesday meetings are attended by fewer OCC residents as per recent OCC policy. In addition, fewer residents are eligible for monthly community visits (passes). Chapel Hill Friends Meeting (CHFM) sponsors are similarly limited. Currently, only three CHFM sponsors are approved to take men out on passes. Residents are limited to two passes per month and sponsors are limited to two passes a month and one resident per pass.

ATTENDANCE of CURRENT and FORMER OCC RESIDENTS in MEETING FOR WORSHIP: Men from CHFM served as sponsors to bring eligible men from OCC to Meeting for Worship, forums, and potluck. Three men periodically attend and one is a regular attender.

OTHER OCC INVOLVEMENT:

Financial Support: TSC provided personal items (pants, shirts, and toiletries) for indigent residents. In addition, TSC conducted an annual fundraiser to support the chaplain and the ministry's activities at OCC.

Meeting for Worship: CHFM and Eno Friends Meeting held one meeting for worship in January. We hope to schedule additional meetings in the upcoming year.

Meeting for Worship with Attention to Healing: CHFM has joined with Eno Friends Meeting to hold monthly meetings at the Peace Center attended by 15 - 20 OCC residents.

Book Club: A monthly book club initiated by CHFM volunteers has continued for the past 9 years.

Writing Group: CHFM volunteers facilitate a twice monthly writing group for approximately 10 men.

INDIVIDUAL SUPPORT TEAMS and RETURNING CITIZENS: The TSC has been providing support teams for returned citizens. These support teams have recently included non-CHFM members. This year, teams have supported 3 recently incarcerated men. Support Teams of 4-5 people assisted them in transportation to government agencies, medical appointments, drivers' education, visits to the gym, and job interviews. Support Teams also provide friendship, and emotional and spiritual support. Finding employment and housing remain as challenges for an individual and for our team in supporting them. In addition, individual TSC members also continue to provide support to various formerly incarcerated men.

OTHER SUPPORT:

Friday morning meetings: First initiated by Richard Miller, Tom McQuiston and Josh Leroy (former chaplain), during COVID, these weekly meetings have continued throughout the year to the present time. These meetings, attended by TSC members and community residents, are held at Weaver Street Market in Hillsborough. The focus of the meetings is community-building between previously incarcerated persons and community persons who support them.

Annual Reunion Picnic: About 20 men with whom we have worked over the past years, attended the event at Blackwood Farm Park in October. CHFM sponsors the picnic for returned citizens and friends to renew old friendships and share their successful re-entry strategies.

Community Resources: TSC members have engaged with community transition programs and specialized support programs.

Donations: TSC committee member delivered boxes of slightly used men's clothing to OCC.

TRANSITION and SUPPORT COMMITTEE : From March 2024 to March 2025, the TSC met via zoom on the first Monday of the month to coordinate team support for individuals and to coordinate our interaction with other organizations and programs. Plans are underway to return to in-person meetings.

Our committee membership this year included Annette Broadwell, Buzz Borchardt, Asta Crowe, Hank Elkins, Nancy Fisher, Sally Fisher, Ronnie Harris, Tom McQuiston, Richard Miller, and John Pilgrim. Several of the long-term members have rotated off of the committee while remaining active in other work. No longer participating are Jefradrian Stafford, Byron Stevens, Bonnie Raphael.

Respectfully submitted,
The Transition and Support Committee

Chapel Hill Monthly Meeting of the Religious Society of Friends
531 Raleigh Road, Chapel Hill, NC 27514
Resident: John Hite (919) 929-5377